

19 Changing emphasis

There are a number of ways that you can change emphasis in English. One way is to use a less common grammatical structure, such as the passive voice.

 **New language** The passive voice

 **Vocabulary** Online learning

 **New skill** Changing sentence emphasis

19.1 KEY LANGUAGE THE PASSIVE VOICE

In a passive sentence, the emphasis is taken away from the agent (the person or thing doing the action), and put on the action itself (or the person or object receiving it).

The focus is on the many people.
Many people studied the book.
The subject of the active verb is the "people."

The focus is on the book.
The book was studied by many people.
The subject of the passive verb is the "book."



19.2 WHEN TO USE THE PASSIVE VOICE

The passive is used when the agent is obvious, unknown, or unimportant. It is also useful when describing a process where the result of the action is important.

The agent is not specified because the verb obviously refers to the police.
Hopefully, the thief will be arrested soon.

The agent is not specified because it is unknown.
Sarah's laptop was stolen from the library.
The agent is not specified because it is the process that is important, not who did it.
The posters are printed on good quality paper.



19.3 HOW TO FORM THE PASSIVE VOICE

To form the passive, use "be" with the past participle. Use "by" when you want to show the agent.

Use different forms of "be" for the past, continuous, future, and perfect forms of the passive.

